been partners against a common foe, though their interests sometimes ran parallel, particularly in resisting American hegemony. The moments of diplomatic convergence were ephemeral, and the two leaderships, civilian and military, have lacked robust structures of trust and communication. This pattern looks set to continue.

Finally, since the early 1980s, India has fallen increasingly behind China in terms of economic, military, and soft power. While the economic power-gap is enormous and insurmountable in the foreseeable future, the military power-gap, while real, is tempered by geography: the intervening mountains and oceanic distances between India and China mean that war and the use of force will at best be limited. India can defend against an attack on its land borders. China lacks sufficient naval power projection to overcome India's natural advantages in the Indian Ocean. The military balance is not static though. If India does not galvanize its indigenous arms industry and if China forges even further ahead in the development of key emerging technologies, the current military balance will turn more decisively against India. As for soft power, China bests India. Overall, on a rough estimate, China may be seven times as powerful as India in terms of comprehensive national power.

Negative mutual perceptions, differences over perimeters, rival partnerships, and the power asymmetry affect each other. The book presents these four drivers of conflict as orthogonal – at right angles to each other, as unrelated – but as suggested above they are intertwined. To show how the four constantly interweave would be a massive task, well beyond the scope of what is intended to be a relatively succinct and accessible account of the relationship between India and China. The reality though is that in combination the four magnify each other and make the conflict even more complex and enduring. My sense is that mutual perceptions and the power asymmetry may be the most serious problems between the two countries. If India and China looked at each more respectfully and if they were on par in terms of capabilities, the border quarrel would probably have been resolved by now. Being in rival partnerships might not have mattered all that much. This is hard to prove of course; it is just an intuition.